irreversible and catastrophic consequences for the survival of Bharat's indigeneity. I believed that it would be unwise to put economics and civilisational priorities in walled gardens because the relationship between the two was too close to risk a silo-based approach. After all, the average person was bound to assume and attribute the West's economic prosperity to the values and ideals it subscribed to, and ultimately to its onto-epistemology and theology (OET).

Also, I asked myself, was it not the ultimate goal to ensure that Indic thought had a respectable seat, its rightful position, at the table of Big Powers? Unless, of course, the true objective was to preserve the hallowed status quo between the seemingly opposing camps, the sacred middle ground where all civilisational enquiry ended regardless of which side of the so-called ideological divide one was on. This was when I started considering the possibility that maybe I was unaware of the existence of an unwritten code that allowed the envelope on the civilisational front to be pushed only so far and no further, thereby maintaining the hegemony of the Western-normative framework in Indian discourse. What else could explain the unquestioned deference with which the framework was being treated by even those who claimed to stand for a living civilisation that placed a premium on self-confidence, critical enquiry and truth?

These questions led me to the view that it was important for people to understand that Bharat as a civilisation was a reality, and reducing that reality and near-unbroken lived experience to a mere talking point to score brownie points over one another was more a proof of expediency than real conviction in the values the Indic civilisation stood for. After all, if one did not believe in the capacity of this civilisation to offer a credible and viable alternative to the Western-normative framework, at least for Bharat, it would be unrealistic to expect the rest of the world to look up to Bharat as the 'Vishwaguru' (literally, teacher or guide to the world). I believed that a people that lacked the courage of their conviction to live by their own civilisational values could hardly expect the world to look up to them for guidance. Also, based on the writings of leonine civilisational icons, such as Swami Vivekananda and Sri Aurobindo, I believed every culture had something of value to contribute to the global pool of thought. It was, therefore, clear to me that recasting Bharat in the mould of the West would kill its originality and character, making it a mere vassal of the West, that too *after* the European coloniser had left its shores. That would be a tragedy